

3. Switch off unnecessary hardware in the BIOS

Since most motherboards today have integrated devices such as Ethernet controllers, FireWire devices, onboard sound and more, during the boot process, the BIOS assigns resources to these devices. In case you don't plan on using these devices, it is advisable to switch them off from the BIOS. Also, there are hardly any devices that use legacy ports such as Parallel and Serial. Unless you do have, say, a serial mouse, it is advisable to switch off these ports too.

Motherboards these days come equipped with RAID solutions; if you're not planning on using a RAID configuration, it is advisable to switch it off.

4. Disable the XP load screen

By disabling the load screen, you can boost the bootup time by a couple of seconds, if not more. To disable the load screen, open the "msconfig" utility: go to Start > Run, type in "msconfig" and press [Enter]. In the subsequent window, select the 'boot.ini' tab. Check the /NOGUIBOOT option and press 'Apply'. Restart windows to see the effect.

5. Disabling unwanted startup programs

You'll generally see that a fresh installation of Windows XP is fast and responsive, and that as time progresses, the system becomes slower—blame it on the tons of applications you install. Today, most applications leave some portion of themselves running in the background as services. These services are launched during bootup without your knowing it. The bootup time slows down as the number of these automatically-launched services increases. There are some applications such as Winamp, Winzip, display properties, etc. that can be switched off for faster bootup times.

The easiest way to remove these unwanted services at startup is by using the "msconfig" utility. The 'Startup' tab in msconfig lists all



Launching the MSCONFIG utility